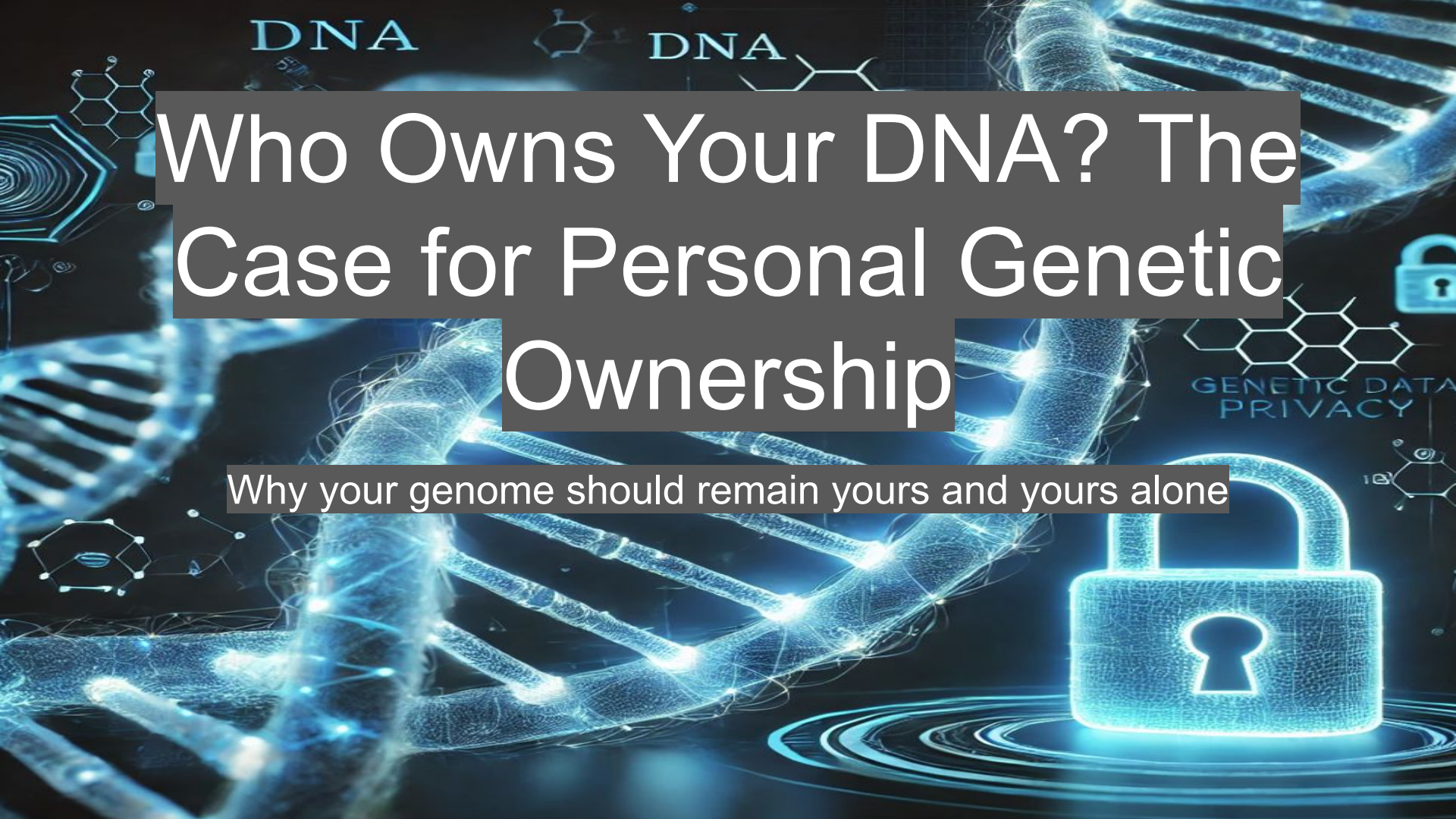

Who Owns Your DNA? The Case for Personal Genetic Ownership

Why your genome should remain yours and yours alone

Individuals should have full ownership over their genetic data

Imagine taking a genetic test and later finding out your data was sold without your consent. Should companies, insurers, or governments control your DNA?

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Why Genetic Data is Unique & Valuable

DNA is a permanent identifier (unlike passwords, it can't be changed). Companies profit from genetic data sales 💰. DNA can reveal health risks, ancestry, and even criminal connections.

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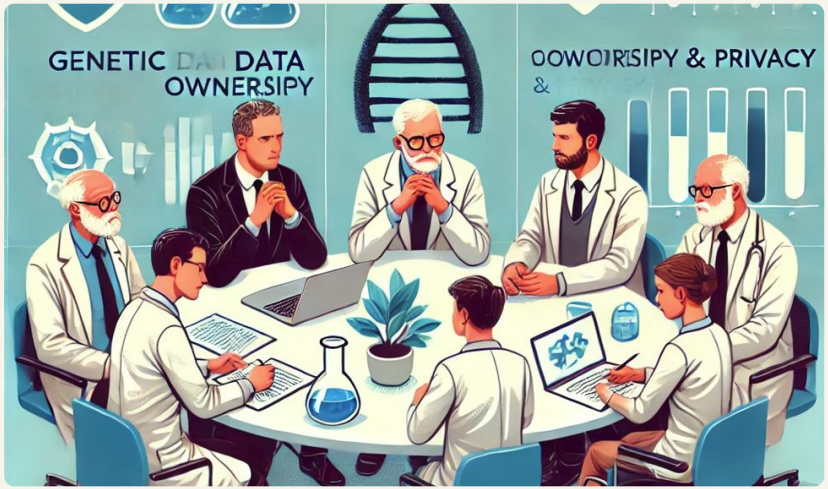
Ethical & Legal Justifications for Personal Ownership



- 1. Ethical Arguments Autonomy: Your genome = your property. Informed Consent: No one should use your DNA without permission. Privacy Rights: Genetic data misuse could lead to discrimination.
- 2. Legal Gaps GINA (2008) protects against job/health insurance discrimination but does not cover life insurance, data sales, or law enforcement access. The Henrietta Lacks case shows the dangers of genetic exploitation.

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The Risks of Losing control of your DNA data

📝 Key Risks: Insurance Discrimination 🚫 – Premiums raised based on genetic risks. Employer Bias – Hiring/firing decisions based on health predictions. Law Enforcement Misuse – Police using ancestry sites for arrests. Pharmaceutical Exploitation – Companies making billions off your DNA without paying you. 🎨

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Counterarguments & Rebuttals 📝 Common Arguments & Responses:

❌ “Companies need genetic data for medical research.”

✅ Research can happen with informed consent and compensation.

Counterarguments & Rebuttals 📝 Common Arguments & Responses:

❌ “Insurers should use DNA to assess risk fairly.”

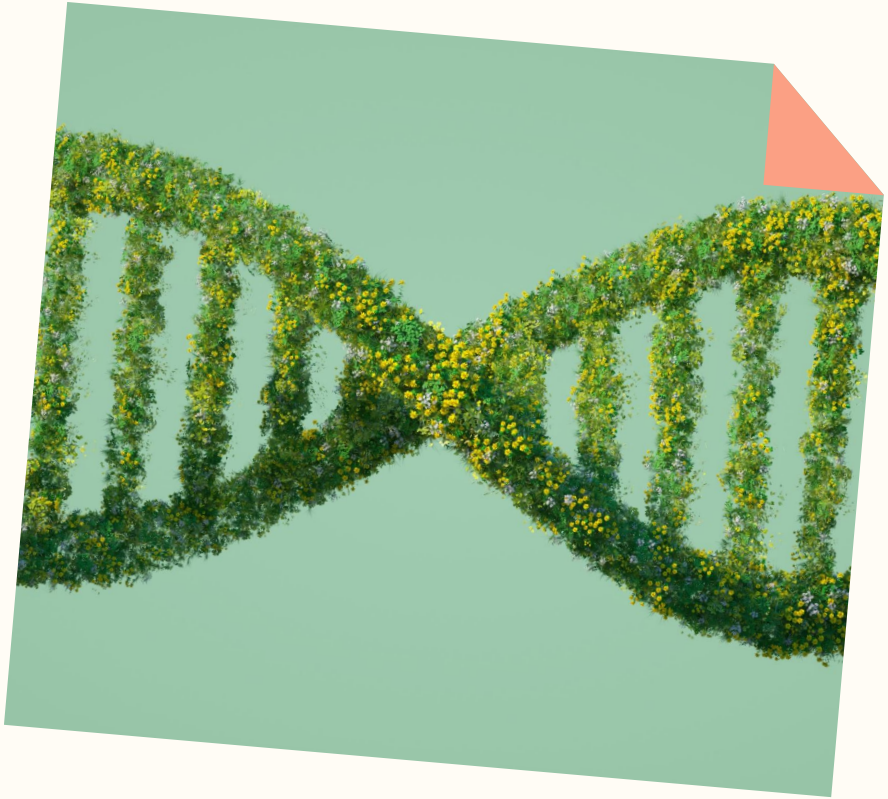
✅ This could create a genetic underclass where people with predisposed conditions are denied coverage.

Counterarguments & Rebuttals 📝 Common Arguments & Responses:

❌ “You voluntarily submit DNA, so companies should have some control.”

✅ Many consumers don’t realize their data is stored & sold indefinitely.

Solutions to Protect Genetic Ownership

📝 What Needs to Change?

✅ Stronger Legal Protections – Expand GINA to cover all forms of genetic discrimination.
✅ Consumer Rights – People should be able to delete or revoke access to their data.
✅ Ethical Research Models – Data trusts where individuals license their genome for research.
✅ Transparency in Data Sales – Companies profiting from genetic data should compensate individuals.